HOW TO WRITE ABOUT THE BRITISH EMPIRE

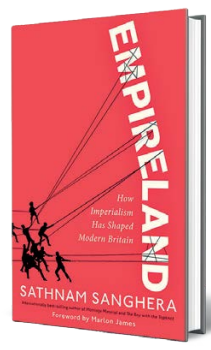
...And how not to do it. Three very different books on a familiar subject

All history is contemporary history, of course, but no rival subfield in our age can match imperial history's claim to ur-contemporaneity. Accordingly, these days one finds middle- and lowbrows in search of a quick buck flocking to it like vultures to offal. Earlier last year, we had Nigel Biggar sounding the bugle for the British Empire in *Colonialism*, which gave us a benevolent NGO staffed by saints spreading enlightened manna to benighted natives. On the strength of its testimony, one could be mistaken for thinking Cecil Rhodes was the best thing that happened to Africa between Augustine and Mandela.

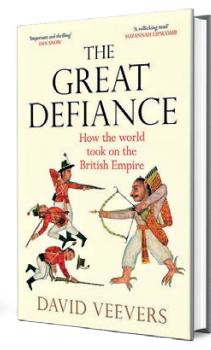
Now we have the journalist Sathnam Sanghera, Biggar's foil but no better historian, who inverts the conceit in *Empireland*, a meandering, whingeing, selective litany of empire's defaults that, understandably, finds room for the Amritsar massacre but not, also understandably, the massacre presided over by the princely ruler of Alwar six years later, a far more brutal episode but unworthy of mention here due to the inconvenient fact that its moving spirit was brown, so an awkward fit with his facile dichotomy between metropole and colony, white and non-white, oppressor and victim.

Likewise, his lurid narrative elides such needless complexities as the fact that peasants incontrovertibly had it better under the Raj than under the Mughals; that most colonial apparatchiks from c. 1850 on were High Tory types who had little time for such niceties as empire's 'civilising mission', preferring to preserve native tradition instead; that, as Gandhi and Naoroji understood well, excepting a few skull-measuring cranks, Brits were by and large a tolerant people; they would turn racist only *after* empire in the sixties. Evidently, Gladstone's Britain was a world away from Enoch Powell's. Sanghera's beef really ought to have been with post-imperial English nationalism rather than empire itself.

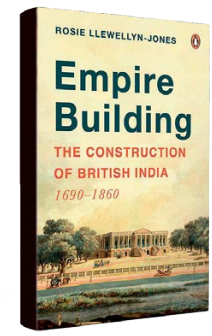
Empire, it seems, explains everything, which is to say nothing at all. 'Sex tourism', we learn, is a product of empire. But somehow, so too is 'official prudery' in the same societies. Sanghera sees the hand of empire in the British penchant for foreign food, tea and curry in particular. But then again, he blames empire for the singularly British 'resistance to foreign food' (sorry, what?). 'Another imperial habit' is 'habitual drunkenness'



EMPIRELAND
How Imperialism Has Shaped Modern Britain
By Sathnam Sanghera
PANTHEON
₹2,274 (hardback); 384 pages



THE GREAT DEFIANCE
How the World Took on the British Empire
By David Veevers
EBURY PRESS
₹799; 512 pages



EMPIRE BUILDING
The Construction of British India, 1690-1860
By Rosie Llewellyn-Jones
PENGUIN
₹799; 256 pages

Historian David Veevers' The Great Defiance is a serious work of history that chronicles the barbarity of colonial conquest